

Reduce Evaluative Gain, Get Access to Joy

A Regime Theory of Joy Series

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Count as "joy": Increased olfaction, increased visual vividness (See Figure 1), chest pleasure, and strong pleasurable emotional reaction to simple music and small, colorful images. The state switches on all at once, like a light being turned on.



Figure 1: Without joy / With joy: Increased visual vividness

The state becomes more solid and easy to re-enter after a first entry. Joy is non-instrumental, but of high intensity, as shown in Figure 2.



Figure 2: Joy is remarkable by its very pleasurable, long-lasting and non-instrumental quality.

What Prevents it: Z, Evaluative Load

Z, described in detail in Figure 3, is felt subjectively as the weight of destiny: the sense that a moment carries evaluation or a next action. It can also be felt as seriousness, as being on a mission, or sometimes as urgency. Self-pursuit is one of its components. Hence why not many adults report daily joy. Even children don't report it, yet actually get it a good share of the day, and we will see why.

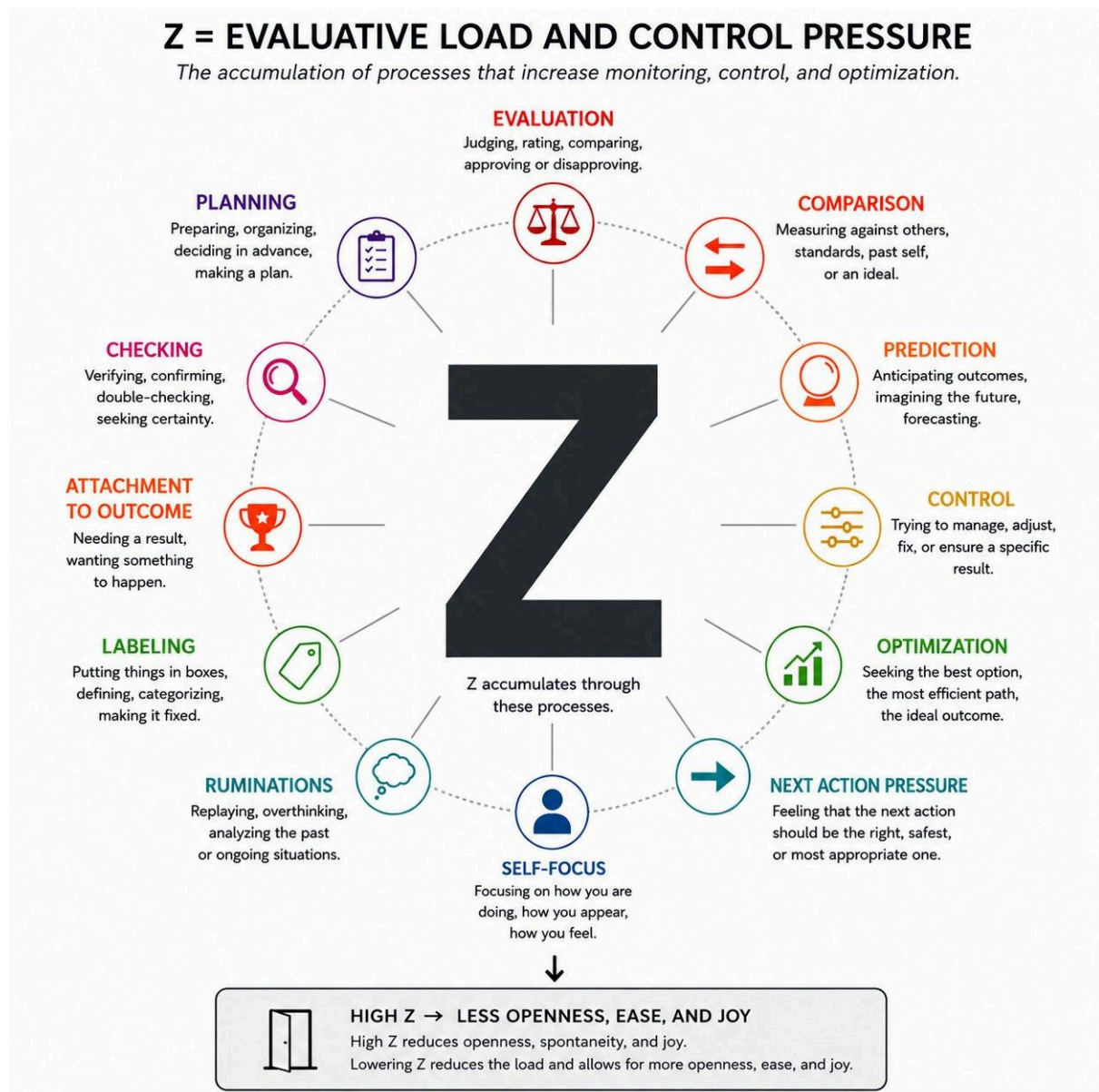


Figure 3: Rumination, self-focus, what to do next, optimization, prediction, comparison, planning, checking for a result, labeling, attachment to outcome (self-pursuit), evaluation, each one progressively increases Z.

In childhood, Z is low, and joy is the default mode, but still collapses in the classroom. As a baseline, children have nothing to compare and barely notice it. In adults, joy does not happen: daily Z is high, and as causal links have been learned, next action pressure is naturally higher, even at rest.

Once Z is elevated, it also increases a bit the pull toward Z high activities. Hence, many people don't try the Z-reduction task, as expected by the model.

Z = Weight of Destiny

The felt load of evaluation, consequence, and next-action pressure.

Daily Life Example

When we have to choose a sidewalk, we give to one side a weight of destiny. Z rises.



Instead, think "The two sides remain equal." Here, you still choose one, but both sides remain briefly equal in importance. Z is low.

However, if you do this at every corner, it becomes "the technique for reducing Z." The exercise itself then acquires a weight of destiny.

The aim is not to eliminate instrumental functioning, but to restore access to a non-instrumental, more pleasant regime.

Lowering Z therefore, is about lowering evaluation, which leads to deliberately flatten experience. Congratulating oneself raises Z. Searching for pleasure, good spots in

nature, the next music, raise Z: Z increases even if evaluation is positive. Even trying to keep the state when one has it, increases Z by a little bit.

In a typical week, Z falls Saturday, but increases sharply Sunday, when planification comes back. That's the regime explanation of the Sunday blues.

You can't induce joy directly, it's not in your hands. As the ease regime is closed in adults, an opening is now in part probabilistic. We know everyone got variations, notably around the ACC - anterior cingulate cortex, the brain area famous for controlling evaluative processes, and a different load of learned causal chains: everyone got a different Z baseline, with a different monitoring architecture (luck).

The Present Moment

Treating the present as important, like we often do, increases its evaluative potential.

One Among Many:

In contrast, briefly framing the moment as "only one moment among many", makes the present not special, and so is not evaluated as much.

Books

Reading a book is a mission-like behavior because of the narrative pressure. Instead:

Paragraph Fragments:

Open a book at any page, and read some lines in an unordered fashion.

Halfway Meaning:

Briefly let something be understood only part way.

Agency

Movements themselves are often directed to a mission.

Stop Agency

See your hands movements as "it happened" instead of being the author.

Objects

You look at your keys and you automatically assign its function. The felt weight of destiny rises.

Category Softening

Soften categories. example: Briefly let an apple seem a little less clearly to be "an apple."

Object with the Wrong Past

Look at an ordinary object and briefly imagine that it came from an absurd past. A chair

was once a boat, and a lamp was found in a cave. Do not explain it. Let the false origin disappear.

Wrong Material

Look at an object and briefly perceive it as made of the wrong material. A wall is soft, a cup is made of paper, a tree is metallic, a screen is cloth. Then let the object return to normal.

Naming Poor

You mentally name an element in a very poor way: "blue", "truck", "hand", "wall", "sound", "image".

Open Questions in Medias

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**Baby Gabriel, saved from
abortion by his surrogate,
deserves the chance to fight
for his life**

ISAAC SCHORR

**A liberal journalist just
exposed lying Fauci's toxic
relationship with the media**

Headlines often do not simply describe an event, but open an unfinished cognitive task. Each headline leaves an implicit question unresolved, such as “What happened?”, “Is this justified?”, or “Who is responsible?” Because no answer is immediately available, monitoring remains active, generating scenarios.

Title Without a Question:

Read a news title but don't treat it as a question that needs an answer.

Social Life Constraints

Waiting for someone, having an appointment, searching for arguments, talking about oneself, or imagining other people's reactions, all increase Z.

Hello for Nothing:

Say “hello” without checking how it was received.

Approval Without Recipients

Generate a feeling of recognition, greeting, or welcoming, as if you were acknowledging someone, but with no recipient.

Passing by

After passing someone, do not review whether your movement, gaze, or hesitation appeared normal.

Don't justify yourself too much. If late, just say "sorry, I am late".

Valuation of Pleasure

Just an Mp4:

Briefly see a video you enjoy as simply an MP4 file.

Ordinary detail:

Briefly notice one visual detail that is irrelevant to what you are doing.

Those 2 exercises may collapse pleasure, which must be tolerated.

The Full Exercises List

Rooms

Actual Setting

Look at the place you're in as if it were already the setting, without needing to go somewhere else. Even if it's lousy, even if it isn't "the right place." Phrase: "This is the setting."

Delayed Commitment

As you enter a room, postpone choosing a destination for just a brief moment. Do not try to maintain the uncertainty. Simply continue when movement resumes naturally.

Let a non-functional part of the scene become as available as the important elements.

Walking

Salute an animal, don't verify his reaction.

Look at someone, don't verify his reaction.

Read a department sign without converting it into a destination.

Notice a reflection on the floor or the brightness of an area without deciding whether the lighting is pleasant.

Hear a sound before deciding what is its source.

A Slight Change of Course

While walking, change your speed very slightly, without a reason, then continue normally. Not enough to be theatrical, just enough to break the autopilot.

Without changing your destination, briefly behave as though arriving a fraction of a second earlier or later makes no difference.

Videos

Briefly notice the colors, shapes, and movement before the story becomes important.

Press play without waiting for the "right moment."

Maybe the next shot..." The prediction never becomes specific.

If something unusual appears, briefly allow several explanations without choosing one.

Before a new object becomes identifiable, let its identity remain briefly open.

Briefly notice the movement itself before identifying what is moving. Notice the music icon as a simple shape before its meaning becomes relevant.

Briefly notice the play button as a shape before it becomes something to click.

Items

Pause Before Utility:

After picking up an object, let it remain in your hand briefly before using it.

For a brief moment, regard a book as just another ordinary object.

Briefly notice several objects together before one becomes the focus.

The Non-Possessive Gaze

Look at an appealing object as if it weren't for you. Not to buy, keep, use, or make part of your identity. Aim: to interrupt the conversion of the world into something to acquire.

Arbitrary Importance:

Briefly label an item as important.

Colors Stand Out:

Briefly see its color instead of its function, then resume.

Computer

Mouse Without a Task

Hold the mouse for a brief moment without any particular purpose.

Cursor Without Hurry

For a brief moment, let the exact timing of the next click matter a little less.

Cursor as an Object

Briefly notice the cursor as a visual shape rather than as a tool.

Cursor Forgot

Move the cursor toward a menu, then let it stop as if the cursor forgot what it was doing

Read *an option* without converting it into "therefore I should/shouldn't choose it."

Notice *a setting* without immediately evaluating whether it is optimal.

Briefly notice a word as a visual object before reading it.

Browse a folder or a page as if no element is the center

Music files

For a moment, see only the file names, not their musical or narrative value.

Look at a title as if you had no idea what genre of music it contains.

Briefly imagine that a cheerful track is melancholic, or vice versa. Don't try to check.

Time

Single Glance

Check the time once. Do not immediately look again to confirm it.

Time Without Meaning

Look at the clock for a moment as if the numbers were simply another visual pattern, then continue normally.

Sometimes notice the current time without mentally calculating how long remains until the appointment.

Let the current year seem no more important than any other.

After seeing the time, do not estimate how much time remains before the next event. Continue with the present activity.

Look at the time and let it be an ordinary time of day for a moment.

Action Pressure

Keep the current action local: walking past the table, turning around the pillar, or looking at one package. Do not connect it to a larger sequence.

An action reaches completion. Notice the completion itself for a moment.

A small action begins before any larger purpose becomes important.

After completing one small action, allow a brief interval before deciding what comes next.

Something ends. For a moment, nothing immediately replaces it.

Briefly allow a small curiosity to arise, such as "Why this color?", "What if I turned left?", or "Why this sound?" Do not try to answer it.

Continue Without Checking

Don't verify the current action when it ends.

Mind

A childhood memory appears for a moment and is allowed to remain incomplete.

Recall a simple memory. Let it disappear on its own without searching for another.

Imagine only part of an object. Let the incomplete image disappear before completing it.

Briefly imagine a familiar face. Let missing details remain missing.

Imagine an object as a visual appearance rather than as something to use. Let the image fade.

Accept the first version of the imagined image without improving its clarity.

Simply notice the instant when the image is no longer there.

Imagine an object once. Do not mentally rotate or inspect it.

Imagine a short sound, such as a bell. Let the internal sound fade naturally.

References

Morin, F. (2026). A Regime Theory of Joy: The Ease Regime as a Permissive Control Configuration. SSRN. <http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6711318>

Morin, Florian, Evaluative Monitoring and Access to Intense Positive Affect: The Minimal Z-Reduction Task Framework (June 06, 2026). Available at SSRN: <https://ssrn.com/abstract=6888300> or <https://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6888300>

Florian Morin proposes that joy is gated by evaluative monitoring: joy does not simply fade, it becomes inaccessible when monitoring and optimization remain active.